

St. Joseph the All Comely Orthodox Texas Prison Ministry Newsletter

Number 7, Nov 18/ Dec 1, 2020, Nativity Fast

Contact Info.....	1
Prison Ministry News	1
“The Beatitudes” with Elder Paisios of the Holy Mountain	1
A Primer for the Christian Beginning to Lead a Spiritual Life – 11-14.....	3
The Good Samaritan. The Incarnation	3
Every Fast Period is resolving with renewed vigor to go to Jerusalem.....	7
Questions & Answers	8
What does “Panaghia” (also spelled “Panagia”) mean?.....	8

http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/newsletter-007_2020-12-01+good-samaritan-incarnation-panagia-spiritual-beatitudes.html

http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/newsletter-007_2020-12-01+good-samaritan-incarnation-panagia-spiritual-beatitudes.docx

http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/newsletter-007_2020-12-01+good-samaritan-incarnation-panagia-spiritual-beatitudes.pdf

Note: With God helping us, we will send many newsletters to all those we minister to in prison. We aim to send a newsletter on at least the first and the 15th of each month. This is the 7th, sent to 74 souls. Those who wish to contribute to our material needs in our ministry to Orthodox Christians may help us with donations at

<http://www.orthodox.net/ministries/orthodox-prison-ministry.html>

Contact Info

Patriarch Joseph the All Comely Texas ORTHODOX Prison Ministry
<http://www.orthodox.net/ministries/orthodox-prison-ministry.html>

Priest Seraphim Holland seraphim@orthodox.net, St. Nicholas Russian Orthodox Church, PO Box 37, McKinney, TX 75070

Priest Cassian Sibley frcassian@yahoo.com, Theotokos of the Life-Giving Spring Russian Orthodox Mission, 1009 Winter Street, Bryan, TX 77803

Priest David Companik davidcompanik@gmail.com, St. Jonah Orthodox Church, PO Box 1427, Spring, TX 77383

NOTE: Fr. David manages our ministry's distribution of Orthodox books, church calendars, icons, and service texts. Contact him if you need something along these lines.

Prison Ministry News

We are still working on getting the property in Marshall. With God's help and your prayers, we will have a place with some of you to go. The most important news is that Fr. Seraphim recently received a letter that said that (at least 1) prison is opening up for primary faith groups. Now, we are not a primary faith group

according to TDCJ; they think of us as the redheaded stepchild of the Roman Catholics. They literally consider us to be part of the Roman Catholics! They must be listening to stuff from Rome and certain unfortunate hierarchs! You should deluge your chaplains with I-60s requesting that we be allowed to come back.

“The Beatitudes” with Elder Paisios of the Holy Mountain

<https://orthodoxword.wordpress.com/2010/10/04/%E2%80%9Cthe-beatitudes%E2%80%9D-with-elder-paisios-of-the-holy-mountain/>

(Taken from the Elder's Sixth Epistle)

Sister Abbess Philothei, your blessing, today, a kind of craziness took hold of me. I took the pencil, as does the madman who writes his outbursts on the wall with charcoal, and I sat down to write my own things on paper like one crazed, and, again, like a lunatic, to send them to you in writing. I am doing this latter craziness out of much love for my Sisters, that they might be edified, even if only a little.



The reason for the initial craziness was five letters, one after the other, from various parts of Greece on a variety of subjects. While the events described were great blessings of God, those who wrote to me had fallen into despair because they dealt with them in a worldly way.

After replying accordingly to their letters, I took the pencil like a madman, as I have said, and wrote this epistle. I believe that even a fifty-cent piece from your journeying brother will be something toward a flint for each one of the Sisters so as to light a little candle in her cell and offer her doxology to our Good God.

I feel great joy when every Sister, with her particular cross carries out the equivalent struggle with philotimo.

It is a small thing to give to Christ a heart equal in size and as luminous as the sun out of gratitude for His great gifts, and

especially for the particular honor He showed us monks by conscripting us with personal summons to His Angelic Order.

A great honor also belongs to the parents who were thus made worthy of becoming related to God. Unfortunately, however, most parents do not realize this and, instead of being grateful to God, are infuriated etc., for they see everything in a worldly way, like those people I mentioned earlier, who became the reason for me to take the pencil and write everything that follows.

1. Blessed are those who loved Christ more than all the worldly things and live far from the world and near God, with heavenly joys upon the earth.
2. Blessed are those who managed to live in obscurity and acquired great virtues but did not acquire even a small name for themselves.
3. Blessed are those who managed to act the fool and, in this way, protected their spiritual wealth.
4. Blessed are those who do not preach the Gospel with words, but live it and preach it with their silence, with the Grace of God, which betrays them.
5. Blessed are those who rejoice when unjustly accused, rather than when they are justly praised for their virtuous life. Here are the signs of holiness, not in the dry exertion of bodily asceticism and the great number of struggles, which, when not carried out with humility and the aim to put off the old man, create only illusions.
6. Blessed are those who prefer to be wronged rather than to wrong others and accept serenely and silently injustices. In this way, they reveal in practice that they believe in “one God, the Father Almighty” and expect to be vindicated by Him and not by human beings who repay in this life with vanity.
7. Blessed are those who have been born crippled or became so due to their own carelessness, yet do not grumble but glorify God. They will hold the best place in Paradise along with the Confessors and Martyrs, who gave their hands and feet for the love of Christ and now constantly kiss with devoutness the hands and feet of Christ in Paradise.
8. Blessed are those who were born ugly and are despised here on earth, because they are entitled to the most beautiful place in Paradise, provided they glorify God and do not grumble.
9. Blessed are those widows who wear black in this life, even unwillingly, but live a white spiritual life and glorify God without complaining rather than the miserable ones who wear assorted clothes and live a spotted life.
10. Blessed and thrice blessed are the orphans who have been deprived of their parents’ great affection, for they managed to have God as their Father already from this life. At the same time, they have the affection they were deprived of from their parents in God’s savings bank “with interest”.

11. Blessed are those parents who avoid the use of the word “don’t” with their children, instead restraining them from evil through their holy life – a life which children imitate, joyfully following Christ with spiritual bravery.
 12. Blessed are those children who have been born “from their mother’s womb” (Mt. 19:12) holy, but even more blessed are those who were born with all the inherited passions of the world, struggled with sweat and up-rooted them and inherited the Kingdom of God in the sweat of their face (Cf. Gen. 3:19).
 13. Blessed are those children who lived from infancy in a spiritual environment and, thus, tirelessly advanced in the spiritual life.
- Thrice blessed, however, are the mistreated ones who were not helped at all (on the contrary, they were pushed towards evil), but as soon as they heard of Christ, their eyes glistened, and with a one hundred and eighty degree turn they suddenly made their soul to shine as well. They departed from the attraction of earth and moved into the spiritual sphere.
14. Fortunate, worldly people say, are the astronauts who are able to spin in the air, orbit the moon or even walk on the moon.
- Blessed, however, are the immaterial “Paradise-nauts”, who ascend often to God and travel about Paradise, their place of permanent abode, with the quickest of means and without much fuel, besides one crust of bread.
15. Blessed are those who glorify God for the moon that glimmers that they might walk at night.
- More blessed, however, are those who have come to understand that neither the light of the moon is of the moon, nor the spiritual light of their soul of themselves, but both are of God. Whether they can shine like a mirror, a pane of glass or the lid of a tin can, if the rays of the sun do not fall on them it is impossible for them to shine.
16. Fortunate, worldly people tell us, are those who live in crystal palaces and have all kinds of conveniences.
- Blessed, however, are those who’ve managed to simplify their life and become liberated from the web of this world’s development of numerous conveniences (i.e., many inconveniences) and were released from the frightening stress of our present age.
17. Fortunate, worldly people say, are those who can enjoy the goods of the world.
- Blessed, however, are those who give away every-thing for Christ and are deprived even of every human consolation for Christ. Thus, it is that they manage to be found night and day near Christ and His divine consolation, which many times is so much that they say to God: “My God, Thy love cannot be endured, for it is great and cannot be fit within my small heart”.

18. Fortunate, worldly people say, are those who have the greatest jobs and the largest mansions, since they possess all possibilities and live comfortably.

Blessed, however, according to the divine Paul, are those who have but a nest to perch in, a little food and some coverings. For, in this way, they've managed to become estranged from the vain world, using the earth as a footstool, as children of God, and their mind is constantly found close to God, their Good Father.

19. Fortunate are those who become generals and government ministers in their head by way of heavy drinking (even if just for a few hours), with the worldly rejoicing over it.

Blessed, however, are those who have put off the old man and have become incorporeal, managing to be earthly angels with the Holy Spirit. They have found Paradise's divine faucet and drink from it and are continually inebriated from the heavenly wine.

20. Blessed are those who were born crazy and will be judged as crazy, and, in this way, will enter Paradise without a passport.

Blessed and thrice blessed, however, are the very wise who feign foolishness for the love of Christ and mock all the vanity of the world. This foolishness for Christ's sake is worth more than all the knowledge and wisdom of the wise of this world.

I beg all the Sisters to pray for God to give me, or rather take from me my little mind, and, in this way, secure Paradise for me by considering me a fool. Or, make me crazy with His love so I go out myself, outside of the earth and its pull, for, otherwise my life as a monk has no meaning. I became externally white as a monk. As I go, I become internally black by being a negligent monk, but I justify myself as one unhealthy, when I happen to be so; other times, I excuse myself again for being ill, even though I am well, and so I deserve to be thoroughly thrashed. Pray for me.

May Christ and Panagia be with you, With love of Christ,
Your Brother, Monk Paisios, ("Precious Cross," December 2, 1972).

A Primer for the Christian Beginning to Lead a Spiritual Life – 11-14

From "A Primer for the Christian Beginning to Lead a Spiritual Life," Hieroconfessor Alexander (Orlov) Of Omsk, who fell asleep in 1977 at the age of 99, translated by Protopresbyter Thomas Marretta. These gems of spiritual wisdom are sent in email messages from my good friend, Fr Demetrios Carellas. We will investigate getting copies of this book to send to many of you. The comments (*in italics*) are from Fr Dimitri. Heed his words! Read the Psalter! The supplicatory canon (Paraklesis) he refers to is in most of your prayer books. (Priest Seraphim)

11. In dangers and trials (*like what is happening now: coronavirus. storms, fires, violent or demeaning protests*), read the Psalter and the Paraklesis, that is, the Supplicatory Canon to the Most Holy Theotokos, which begins, "By many temptations am I distressed." The teacher is a fervent intercessor for Christians. (*I recommend that all Orthodox Christians read at least one Psalm a day and read that Paraklesis at least once a week. We all need to get closer to our Most Beloved Panaghia, who loves us so very much!*)

12. When demons loose their arrows at you, when you are threatened by sin, chant hymns of Great [and Holy] Week and Holy

Pascha, or read the Canon and Akathist to Sweetest Jesus, and the Lord will enlighten your mind and loosen your shackle.

13. If circumstances prevent you from singing and reading, then, at the moment of temptation, remember the Name of Jesus, stand noetically before the Cross, and tears will bring healing.

14. Observe fast days, but remember that God is not pleased with mere abstinence of the belly. He wants our hearts to renounce the passions.

The Good Samaritan. The Incarnation

Luke 10:25-37

We are in the Nativity Fast. Before or at the beginning of the fast, we always read the Parable of the Good Samaritan in Sunday Liturgy. This parable answers the question "Who is my neighbor" by describing the incarnation in a parable. If we are to be Christian in any way, we must understand this parable and have it resonate in our souls. The person who has these words living in his soul not only understands the infinite beauty of the incarnation and the reason why it was necessary, but he also does not need anyone to ask him, "Who is your neighbor?". This parable is "required reading" and teaching for all those who desire to become Orthodox Christians. [Priest Seraphim Holland]

In the Name of the Father and the Son and the Holy Spirit, Amen¹. Today, on the threshold of the Nativity Fast, we read about the Greatest Commandment and the story of the Good Samaritan. There are two teachings, set parallel to one another, like two plots in a story. One has an outward and moral aspect, concerning how we should act as Christians, being compassionate, and who is our neighbor.

We know the answer to that. Everyone is our neighbor. We just need to be reminded of that sometimes. There is also a

mystical and internal story here that is right alongside this critical teaching about being compassionate. What gives us the power, the ability, to act with compassion? What gives us the ability to live the Christian life? Of course, we know, it is only God's grace, but how did He give us this ability and this power? In this story, we can see it when we look at the mystical meaning that the Fathers have elucidated. We can see also what the essence of Christianity is and the purpose and activity of the church. There is a great promise in this story and a great source of hope for us.

“And, behold, a certain lawyer stood up, and tempted him, saying, Master, what shall I do to inherit eternal life?”²

A lawyer was a Jew who studied and interpreted the law. He was not like we understand lawyers to be today. They should have been men of character and high moral standing. Many of them were, but too many were not. This lawyer was like the people Jesus referred to when He said: *“But woe unto you, Pharisees! for ye tithe mint and rue and all manner of herbs, and pass over judgment and the love of God: these ought ye to have done, and not to leave the other undone.”*³ If you know this passage, from St. Luke’s Gospel, a sentence or so later, a lawyer told Jesus He was judging them also, and our Lord said ‘yes, indeed.’

This lawyer was trying to trap Jesus. He was trying to get Him to say something where they could judge Him. Already they hated Him. In the first year of His ministry, some people wanted to put Him to death. The bloom was off the rose very quickly for these people when they saw what Jesus meant and how they would have to change their lives if they followed him. They didn’t want to do it. They didn’t want to give up their positions and their lands and everything else⁴. This lawyer was one of many flunkies who would go to Christ and try to trip Him somehow. This question that he asks is amazing. It is a foolish question. To stand in front of the God-man and ask him ‘what should I do to inherit eternal life’ – is to be filled with pride and self-absorption.

Christ refers him to the law because Christ upheld the law. His answer should have been enough for him, just it should have been enough for the rich man and his brothers, since they had the law and the prophets.⁵ He also wanted to show how one can be a lawyer, and know all manner of things about the law, and how one could, to extend it to our time – know all manner of things about the Saints, and the Typicon, and the church, and yet, not understand the inner meaning and the essence of what our life is all about.

“He said unto him, What is written in the law? How readest thou? And he answering said, Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy strength, and with all thy mind; and thy neighbor as thyself.”⁶

Foolish wretched man! He actually knows the correct answer to the question, and he says it like some school child reciting the answer in a test and having a smug grin on his face because he got the answer right. The amazing thing is that he had previously listened to Christ because nowhere in the Old Testament does it explicitly name these commandments as the “Greatest Commandments,” and they do not appear anywhere in the “Ten Commandments.” The first portion of his quotation is from Deuteronomy, and the second part is from Leviticus. This fusion of the two commandments into the “Greatest Commandment” and the “Second, which is like it” is from the teaching of the God-man, Jesus Christ. Our Lord was teaching the people what the law meant- The essence of the law is the love of God, and because we are made in the image of God, our love for God, and because of our love for

God, the love of neighbor naturally follows. After quoting Deuteronomy, He said:” *And the second is like it, namely this, Thou shalt love thy neighbor as thyself. There is none other commandment greater than these.”*⁷ The lawyer must have heard this! He knew the right answer but did not believe it because he did not live it.

If you believe these words, then you will heed Christ’s other words. He said: *“A new commandment I give unto you, That ye love one another; as I have loved you, that ye also love one another. By this shall all men know that ye are my disciples, if ye have love one to another.”*⁸ Love is the hallmark of what a Christian is. Without love, we truly are nothing, and are hypocrites, and are most to be pitied.

Christ says to the lawyer: **“Thou hast answered right: this do, and thou shalt live.”⁹**

It is very simple! Christ reveals the truth to us, and we follow Him! We love Him. We want to do things pleasing to Him because it is innate in us to want to please God – not because of fear of punishment or hope of reward, but because HE IS! And we want to follow Him, because of that only. As you progress in the Christian life, even a little bit, you come to the realization that you want to do good and follow God’s commandments because of how sweet they are. You want to do nothing else.

You may fall many times; nonetheless, you must inculcate that desire in your heart! It does not matter how many times you fall, seventy times seven times, or seventy times seven plus one!¹⁰ I don’t care how many times. You must plant in your heart this desire to follow God’s commandments. All Christ is saying is, “You know the answer. Now go do it!”. The Christian life is not something we just talk about or read in a book. It is not something we say we believe. It is WHAT WE DO BECAUSE OF WHAT WE BELIEVE.

Christ’s response puts the lawyer back on his heels. He did not expect such a simple, forthright answer. He thought he was doing pretty well. He had gotten the first answer right and was ready for more with the audience surrounding them, but Christ simply amazed him with such a simple response. He had to recover. Instead of falling at His feet and worshipping Him and realizing that he had been full of pride, he lets his pride master him.

“But he, willing to justify himself, said unto Jesus, And who is my neighbor?”¹¹

The lawyer asks another very foolish, wretched question. He can say sweet words, but he does not know that they taste sweet. He can say that “thou shalt love thy neighbor,” but he doesn’t do it. He wants to put himself on a pedestal. He wants to think himself better than some men! Indeed, he believes that some others are his equal – the other lawyers, the people of learning, and those that wash every day and are not smelly, but he put himself above some of humanity. This story that we are now about to discuss certainly resoundingly tells him, ‘Lawyer, everyone is your neighbor.’

This story says something else more incredibly beautiful and incredibly sweet. It presents the mystical teaching of Christ the Healer and also explains that the church is to continue that role of healing and to integrate the personality with Christ. It teaches us that we can recognize our neighbor by knowing ourselves and the purpose of the incarnation for us.

All of us, to some extent, are fractured. Our personality is not integrated with God's will, and we suffer grievously because of it. Our whole life in the church is therapeutic. We are being remade and being made whole. It is as if we are missing a leg, and we are given a perfect leg. We don't have eyes to see, and we are given eyes. All of our senses are being given to us in greater and greater measure so that we can truly see and understand God, Who is. Jesus makes a concise answer to the lawyer. He never answers him directly, because why should you answer a proud man with a direct response? They will just have another come back. Instead, He answers in a way that cannot be gainsaid. And he says it all in one hundred and eighty-six words!

Listen very carefully now. There is outward teaching here, and the inward teaching will give us great hope and make us realize how great is our God. It will also teach us the "open secret" that, if we know it, will give us the reason – and power! – to love everyone, our neighbors, because the Samaritan came for everyone. We are like everyone. We also would be lying almost dead on the side of the road without the incarnation.

"And Jesus answering said, A certain man was going from Jerusalem to Jericho, and fell among thieves, which stripped him of his raiment, and wounded him, and departed, leaving him half dead."¹²

The road from Jerusalem to Jericho was a dangerous route. It was sweltering and went down into the valley, and Jericho was very uncomfortable compared to Jerusalem. Jerusalem is an image of salvation and peacefulness in the scriptures and the writings of the fathers. Doesn't it say: *"Great is the LORD, and greatly to be praised in the city of our God, in the mountain of his holiness. Beautiful for situation, the joy of the whole earth, is mount Zion, on the sides of the north, the city of the great King."*¹³

Jerusalem is an image of salvation, and Jericho is an image of the passions, strife, cacophony, and unwholeness.

Who is this man? He is Adam and the entire human race. This man is human nature. God created us perfect. He created us so that we would know Him, and then we fell. We would all proceed down towards Jericho, except that the God-man intervenes and saves us. In the original language, the words **"was going (down)"** implies a continual motion down, and the Fathers stress this. Without the "Good Samaritan's" intervention, ALL OF US would be continually descending further into sin and death.

Who are the thieves? They are the demons. What do these demons do? They strip a man of his raiment. This raiment is our virtue. They strip a man of virtue, and then they wound him with

sins. Then they leave him half dead, not totally destroyed, because God is merciful, and there is still breath in us, and there is still hope for our salvation. Also, the fathers tell us that even though our body dies, our soul lives.

"And by chance there came down a certain priest that way: and when he saw him, he passed by on the other side. And likewise a Levite, when he was at the place, came and looked on him, and passed by on the other side."¹⁴

The outer meaning here is that these Jews knew the law, and they did not want to touch a man that might be dead. That would soil them, and they would be obliged to wash and would not be able to go into the temple for some time. They valued their position and status, and comfort more than another man. They did not even go to look at him and went to the other side, these wretched, foolish men!

Listen to what the Fathers say is the inner meaning. The law and prophets cannot change a man! The problem is too difficult. We are too broken. We are too wounded. We are bleeding from everywhere, and we are weakened. When they passed by, this indicates that our sins are too much for us. We cannot do anything with them on our own. The Lord also says that "by chance" they came upon the dying man; Not by purpose, but by chance, because a man's purpose in life cannot be to save another man. He can certainly assist, as God asks him to, especially those in the church that are appointed to this task, and also in some measure, all of us, but no man can save another. Only God can save.

"But a certain Samaritan, as he journeyed, came where he was: and when he saw him, he had compassion on him"¹⁵

His journey was to come TO the man. It wasn't a chance occurrence. This Samaritan (our Lord and Savior, Jesus Christ is the Samaritan in this parable, brothers, and sisters), journeyed to come to each one of us by the side of the road. That is the meaning is here. When He saw us, and as he continues to see us, He has compassion. His purpose on the earth was to come to save us and help us in every way.

"And" (He) "went to him, and bound up his wounds, pouring in oil and wine, and set him on his own beast, and brought him to an inn, and took care of him."¹⁶

Oh, there is much here to know. What does the binding up of wounds mean? Do you have any sins that, like the woman with an issue of blood, whom we talked about last week¹⁷, sins that hemorrhage, and you cannot stop the bleeding? Don't you need some binding of that wound to stop the bleeding? That is what Christ does. He binds us, He helps us, not binding us against our will, but He helps us with self-control. Whatever sin you have, you cannot name a sin that God will not help you conquer.

He poured in oil and wine. This oil and wine refer to the dual natures of Christ. It also refers to the two ways in which Christ acts, and indeed, how all of the teachings and actions of the church (His body) work. Some teachings are merciful and are gentle. They

are promises and things that give us hope and comfort us. Some teachings are harder. They tell us when we are foolish or doing things that are evil or dangerous.

Some of the soothing words that Christ said are these:

“In my Father's house are many mansions: if it were not so, I would have told you. I go to prepare a place for you. And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again, and receive you unto myself; that where I am, there ye may be also.”¹⁸

Ye are my friends, if ye do whatsoever I command you. Henceforth I call you not servants; for the servant knoweth not what his lord doeth: but I have called you friends; for all things that I have heard of my Father I have made known unto you. Ye have not chosen me, but I have chosen you, and ordained you, that ye should go and bring forth fruit, and that your fruit should remain: that whatsoever ye shall ask of the Father in my name, he may give it you. These things I command you, that ye love one another.”¹⁹

“Take my yoke upon you, and learn of me; for I am meek and lowly in heart: and ye shall find rest unto your souls. For my yoke is easy, and my burden is light.”²⁰

Those are the teachings that are like oil, soothing. We need this oil, just as our children need to be comforted, many times. We are like children that need to be comforted, that repeatedly need to be told that God loves us, and indeed, has a place prepared for us.

He has also given us hard teachings. Some of these teachings seem hard to us because of our hard-heartedness, and they are very hard for a person who doesn't want to change. He said:

“Enter ye in at the strait gate: for wide is the gate, and broad is the way, that leadeth to destruction, and many there be which go in thereat: Because strait is the gate, and narrow is the way, which leadeth unto life, and few there be that find it.”²¹

“Not every one that saith unto me, lord, lord, shall enter into the kingdom of heaven; but he that doeth the will of my Father which is in heaven.”²²

He also says something about the last judgment, the last part of which are words that I hope none of us will hear:

“Whosoever therefore shall confess me before men, him will I confess also before my father which is in heaven. But whosoever shall deny me before men, him will I also deny before my father which is in heaven.”²³

All scriptures are full of these oil and wine teachings, mixed together because our Lord and Savior was, and is, God and man.

He put him on his own beast. What does that mean? The beast signifies the incarnation.

He took a sick and a dying man, and he raised him, and he gave him the ability to live! He took on flesh and made this flesh able to comprehend and apprehend God. Beforehand, it wasn't

possible because we were lying by the road, all bruised and bleeding, but he put us on His beast – He became incarnate for our sake. He is our strength when we are weak. He carries us at all times, at every moment, because of His love for us. And He loves our flesh.

“And on the morrow when he departed, he took out two pence, and gave them to the host, and said unto him, Take care of him; and whatsoever thou spendest more, when I come again, I will repay thee.”²⁴

The departing is His ascension. He did not live on the earth forever, but after a very short time, He left his church's administration to His servants, to the innkeeper, his bishops, His priests, and His deacons. He told them to take care of those who need care. And he gave them two pence. A coin is stamped on both sides with the image of the emperor. Two pence are the old and the new testaments, Holy Scripture and holy tradition. These are how a man finds truth, by the Holy Scriptures, and the Holy Church, which wrote the scriptures and has added much more besides, as the Holy Spirit has willed it.

What is this ‘taking care’? How do we care for these people? Through all the ways we live in the church, through confession, counsel, teaching, preaching, the services, and blessings. Through praying for one another, and especially, even if he be unworthy, through the priest and the bishop praying and interceding for the people before the holy altar, as God has ordained. Also, may God grant that they would be strong enough to be an example to others, these innkeepers.

“And whatever thou spendest more” – We are going to spend more. God gives us, but we must increase. God makes the increase and causes growth, but we supply the labor²⁵ and grow our talents. Whatever you spend more (God will remember a cup of water that you give to a thirsty man²⁶), every prayer that you say for a person, every prostration, every tear – nothing will be forgotten. And when He comes again, all things will be made known, both good and bad, and He will repay us.

Do you understand the sweetness of this parable and how it applies to us? We are the man by the road. We are that man bleeding, and the Samaritan, our Lord, Jesus Christ, came and bound us and helped us stop sinning. He did not just lay down commandments. He did not just lay down laws and say, “you must do this, and do this and do this, or you will be damned.”

He came and helped us. And as we become stronger, we react to His love, just as a child responds to the love of his parents, and wants to do better, and wants to please them, and we will do His commandments. And He sometimes pours oil, and sometimes wine into us. Sometimes we need to be rebuked, and sometimes we need to be comforted. And He makes us able to live.

This man that went to the inn recovered and became stronger, just as it is, and continues to be with us! We should have hope; we should have absolute certainty that God will save us

because that is why He came. That is why He journeyed. That is why The Samaritan went to the dusty road where we were lying in the ditch.

He will save us if we only react to Him, if we only cooperate with the therapeutic care that He gives to us. If you go under the care of a physician and do not do anything the physician says, you will not get better. All we need to do is listen to our Great Physician. God will save us. God will bind up our wounds continually, and eventually, the wounds will go away. The passions will go away, not in a short time, although, if we have great fervor, it will go away in a very short time. If we have fervor and great

desire, God will help us more quickly. If we choose the hard path (as Jairus did— he did not have as much faith and wanted Christ to come to his house and lay hands on his child), then we will have a longer road. Unfortunately, we have that longer road because of our lack of faith, arrogance, and our addiction to sins. But regardless of whether it is a longer road or a shorter road for us, God will save us. Amen.

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost-sunday-25_1999-11-24+parable-of-the-good-samaritan_luke10-25-37.html

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost-sunday-25_1999-11-24+parable-of-the-good-samaritan_luke10-25-37.html

Every Fast Period is resolving with renewed vigor to go to Jerusalem.

Then he took unto him the twelve, and said unto them, Behold, we go up to Jerusalem, and all things that are written by the prophets concerning the Son of man shall be accomplished. For he shall be delivered unto the Gentiles and shall be mocked, and spitefully entreated, and spitted on: And they shall scourge him, and put him to death: and the third day he shall rise again. And they understood none of these things: and this saying was hidden from them, neither knew they the things which were spoken. 27th Thursday after Pentecost: Luke 18:31-34

"Then he took unto him the twelve, and said unto them, Behold, we go up to Jerusalem."

Is it not fitting that at or near the beginning of the Nativity Fast, when we prepare for the remembrance of the beginning of Our Lord Jesus Christ's earthly life, He speaks of its end? If one reads the gospels carefully, it is clear that our Lord was "going to Jerusalem" all of His life. He knew that He was born to die, that we might live. All that He did was towards this goal.

These words are an important reminder for us as we begin the fast. This season has many distractions, but one thing is needful. Our Lord was born to "go to Jerusalem." If we are to imitate His example as we are called to do, since He commanded us to "take up

our cross and follow him," then we are to "go to Jerusalem." Our Lord went to die and give us life.

Let us, therefore, go to die, that we may have life. Let us die to our self-will and all things that lead away from life. Let us die to our self-centeredness and pride. Let us, with great force, make all that is within us that is unholy die. And let us go to Jerusalem and live.

Jerusalem is the Holy City, the city of the Great King. It represents all that is holy and good. Our Lord's path to Jerusalem was not for Himself, as He is already holy and good, but for us. We must retrace his steps to the Holy City. We must take His yoke upon us, learn of Him, and carry our personal cross with forbearance and faith. There is no other way to reach Jerusalem, our salvation, because it is the Lord's way, and what He accomplished in Jerusalem enables us to walk this path and be victorious over sin and death.

It is always good to be reminded of good things, even if we already have heard about them. Let us be reminded now that the purpose of our Lord's Nativity was so that He would "go to Jerusalem" and accomplish our regeneration. We must daily remember that we are also born to "go to Jerusalem."

http://www.orthodox.net/scripture/pen-thu-27_2008+a-fast-is-a-journey-towards-jerusalem_luke-18-31-34.html



Questions & Answers

What does “Panaghia” (also spelled “Panagia”) mean?

“Panagia” is a Greek word, but many Orthodox Christians say it. It’s popular among Greek Orthodox monks. The word means “all-holy,” and it refers to Mary, the mother of Jesus, the Theotokos, the Mother of God. It is a compound word, consisting of “Pan” and Agios (πᾶν, Ἅγιος, the Greek words for “all,” “holy”)

We call her “All-Holy” because she bore Jesus Christ, Who is All-holy. Of course, the title is hyperbolic (an exaggeration) because only God is all-holy, but we use this term in love and with great reverence because, of all mortal human beings, the Theotokos is the holiest and most obedient.

In the Akathist service (in most of your prayerbooks or), we call her “holiest of all holies (Saints)”: “O all-praised Mother who didst bear the Word holiest of all the Saints, accept now our

offering, and deliver us from all misfortune, and rescue from the torment to come those that cry to thee: Alleluia!” (Kontakion 13)

We also call her by this title because we believe that at the moment of the incarnation, after she was perfectly obedient to the will of God and said “behold the handmaid of the Lord,” the Holy Spirit came upon her, and she attained to “theosis,” which is union with God. We believe that because she bore God (the God-man, Jesus Christ) in her womb for nine months and raised Him and was with Him in His ministry, there was nothing worldly or secular or sinful in her from the time of the Annunciation.

God did not make her holy without the express cooperation of her will. God also will help us to become holy, but always in cooperation with our will. We venerate the Panagia because she, more than any other human being, obeyed God. (P. Seraphim)

¹ This homily was transcribed from one given On November 11, 1996 according to the church calendar (11/24 ns), being the Twenty Fifth Sunday after Pentecost, and the day appointed for the commemoration Holy Martyrs Menas of Egypt, Victor and Stephanida at Damascus and Vincent of Spain The Epistle reading appointed is Ephesians Eph 4:1-6, and the Gospel is Luke 10:25-37. There are some stylistic changes and minor corrections made and several footnotes have been added, but otherwise, it is essentially in a colloquial, “spoken” style. It is hoped that something in these words will help and edify the reader, but a sermon read from a page cannot enlighten a soul as much as attendance and reverent worship at the Vigil service, which prepares the soul for the Holy Liturgy, and the hearing of the scriptures and the preaching of them in the context of the Holy Divine Liturgy. In such circumstances the soul is enlightened much more than when words are read on a page.

² Luke 10:25

³ Luke 11:42

⁴ The second Gospel read on the day of this homily was the Reading appointed for Martyr Menas and the other martyrs is Matthew 10:32-33,37-38,19:27-30. At the end of the reading, Christ says: “Verily I say unto you, that ye which have followed me, in the regeneration when the Son of man shall sit in the throne of his glory, ye also shall sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel. And every one that hath forsaken houses, or brethren, or sisters, or father, or mother, or wife, or children, or lands, for my name's sake, shall receive an hundredfold, and shall inherit everlasting life.” (Matthew 19:28-29).

⁵ The story of the Rich man and Lazarus is in Luke 16:19-31, and is read on the 16th Sunday after Pentecost. The rich man, in hell, wanting to save his brothers, has the following discussion with the Holy Prophet Abraham: “I pray thee therefore, father, that thou wouldest send him to my father's house: For I have five brethren; that he may testify unto them, lest they also come into this place of torment. Abraham saith unto him, they have Moses and the prophets; let them hear them. And he said, Nay, father Abraham: but if one went unto them from the dead, they will repent. And he said unto him, If they hear not Moses and the prophets, neither will they be persuaded, though one rose from the dead.” (Luke 19:27-31)

⁶ Luke 10:26-27 (cf. Duet 6:5: “And thou shalt love the LORD thy God with all thine heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy might.”

⁷ Mark 12:31

⁸ John 13:34-35

⁹ Luke 10:28

¹⁰ Cf. Matthew 18:22. This expression, “seventy times seven” is an indication of an infinite number.

¹¹ Luke 10:29

¹² Luke 10:30

¹³ Psalm 48:1-2

¹⁴ Luke 10:31-32

¹⁵ Luke 10:33

¹⁶ Luke 10:34

¹⁷ The Gospel for the 24th Sunday after Pentecost, read the preceding week, is Luke 8:41-56. It tells the story of the healing of the woman with an issue of blood, and the raising of Jairus’ daughter.

¹⁸ John 14:2-3

¹⁹ John 15:14-17

²⁰ Matthew 11:29-30

²¹ Matthew 7:13-14

²² Matthew 7:21

²³ Matthew 10:32-33

²⁴ Luke 10:35

²⁵ Cf. 1 Cor. 3:6 “I have planted, Apollos watered; but God gave the increase.”

²⁶ Cf. Mark 9:41 “For whosoever shall give you a cup of water to drink in my name, because ye belong to Christ, verily I say unto you, he shall not lose his reward.”